



The Mayflower attempted to depart England on three occasions: from Southampton and then Dartmouth in August, and finally from Plymouth on September 6, 1620.

had been established by English colonists in 1607 under a charter from the Crown, and was their first permanent settlement in the Americas. French explorers had established fur trading posts up the rivers of Canada, Dutch and Swedish colonists arrived in North America in the early 17th century, and in 1613 the Dutch established a trading post on the western shore of Manhattan Island.

Government and trade

Both Plymouth and Jamestown developed representative institutions in which colonists elected officials to govern their own affairs. Inspired by the English parliamentary model, and growing out of the assertion of rights articulated in the *Mayflower Compact*, these early

developments established a model of self-rule that came to characterize English colonization in North America.

Each colony had a governor, appointed by the British monarch, and a legislature, elected by the colonists. There was often tension between the two, because the legislature had to work within the framework of existing English law. However, the king and government in London, working with the governor, saw the colonies as a resource, rich in raw materials, that they could exploit to their advantage.

To ensure America remained a ready market for British industry, colonial trade was restricted by the Navigation Acts, which required that all commodity trade take place in British ships crewed by British sailors. The colonists came to see these measures as a willful suppression of their trade and manufacturing. Tensions arose on both sides of the Atlantic as British and colonial merchants sought to protect their interests.

Colonial growth

Relations between the colonists and the indigenous peoples of the East Coast were also starting to strain. The increasing colonial population put pressure on land and resources, pushing people west to settle on land belonging to American Indians.

The groups struggled to coexist harmoniously. An uneasy peace, punctuated by violence, typified relations between settlers and Native Americans for many years. ■

Religious persecution

In the early 17th century, the English were legally obliged to worship as prescribed by the Church of England. Although the English church had already broken from the Catholic Church, many people still felt that its hierarchical priesthood

and set rituals, hymns, and prayers were Catholic features that should be swept away.

Puritans, so-called because of their desire for religious purity, hoped to reform the church from within. Other groups, known as Separatists, set up their own "separate" congregations, but when their leaders were imprisoned or even

executed, they moved to the more tolerant Netherlands. Here they could adopt the simpler form of worship they preferred, but it was very hard to earn a living because the country's professional guilds were closed to them. This is part of the reason that the Pilgrims, and later others, decided to seek a new life in North America.